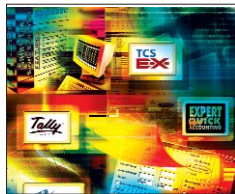




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Digital Business

How Technology Can Help Your Organisation

Case Study

The Other Side

Can you imagine life without MS Office? Is there an alternative? StarOffice could just be the answer you are looking for

Ram Mohan Rao

Microsoft is the undisputed leader in office suites, and MS Office is the *de facto* standard when it comes to choosing an office software package. For those who came in late, alternatives exist. And they are cheaper too! One such alternative is StarOffice—Sun Microsystems' offering for the office environment, priced much lower than MS Office.

As the chief technology or information officer of your company, you might wonder about using something like StarOffice instead of MS Office, given the 'unknown' aura surrounding it. So we decided to learn more about it, and investigated if any corporate setup was implementing it.

We came across Apnaloan.com. Apnaloan.com is a leading mediator for financial products in

the form of loans, insurance and credit cards, to name a few. Amongst the four first-generation entrepreneurs who founded apnaloan.com is Parag Patankar, chief information officer and director, Insurance. An IIM Ahmedabad alumnus and an engineer from IIT Kanpur, he spent two years at the Project Finance Division of ICICI Ltd before moving to Corporate Banking in ICICI Bank where he spent three-and-a-half years in various capacities. We decided to find out from him what it's like to use StarOffice and MS Office in tandem.

It's All About The Money...

Apnaloan.com started in 2000 with the traditional MS-based Office Productivity environment. It was not until 2003 that they started looking at alternatives, mainly from a cost perspective. The licensing cost for MS Office is around Rs 8,000 per license for the Small Business Edition, while the Professional Edition retails at around Rs 12,000. In contrast, StarOffice 7 retails

Illustration: Shyam Shrivastava

